

Vertigo

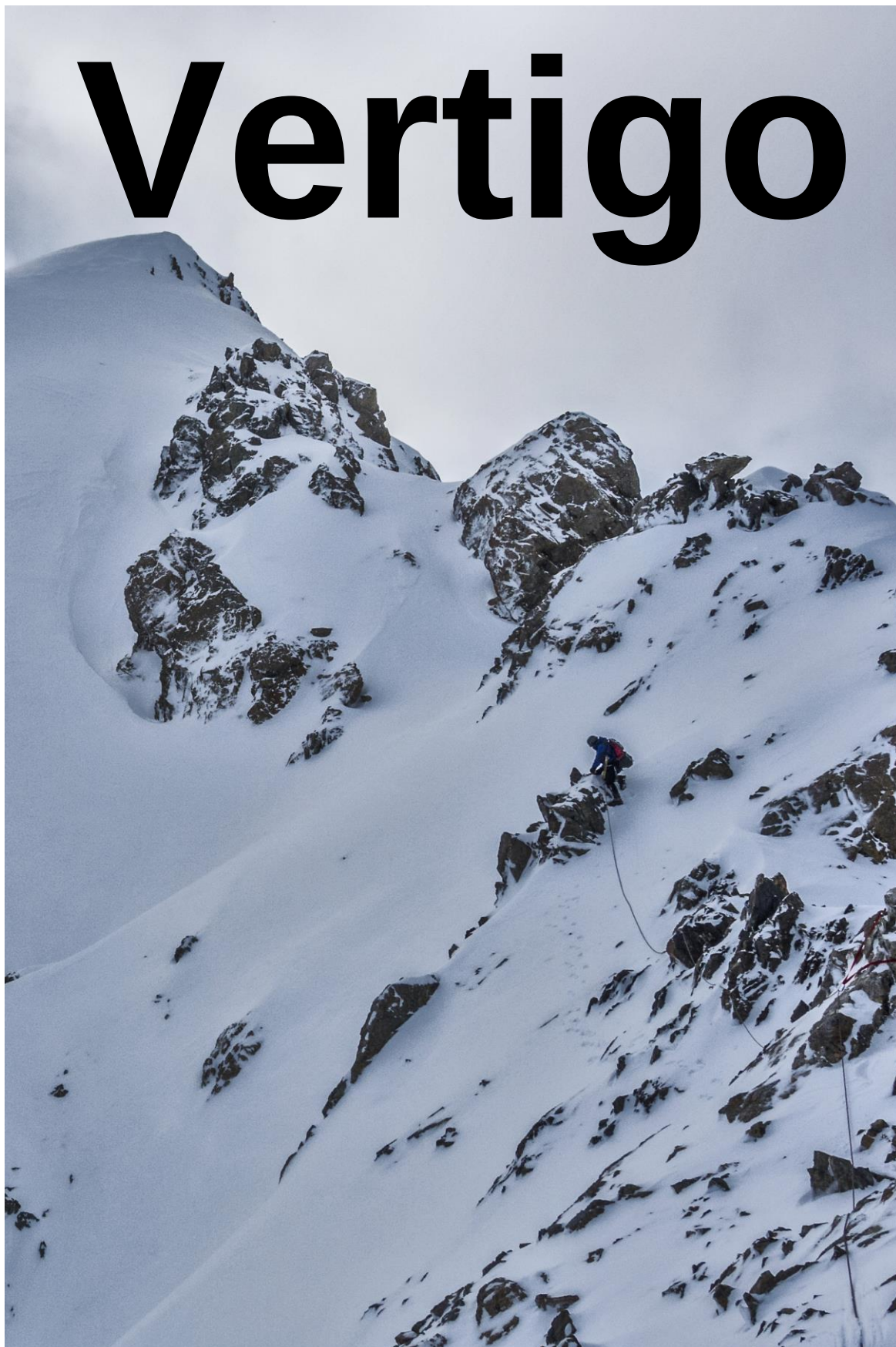


Photo: Below the summit of Mt Temple (photo by Peter Laurensen)

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club - Wellington Section

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Section News

Section Nights

Our October section night was well-attended with between 55 and 60 attendees at the Southern Cross to learn about risk management and decision making in the mountains from Rohan Light and also for Mark Henson and Don French to tell us about Tukino.

In November, Erik Bradshaw is coming along to talk about "Skiing the long white cloud – a journey the length of the Southern Alps". In 2011 Erik made the first ski traverse the length of the Southern Alps. We will hear how he tackled an adventure that, on first consideration, seemed impossible – inventing his own equipment, managing the physical challenges and exploring the capabilities of the human mind. This will be a talk as much about personal experiences as the spectacular landscape he traversed.

In December we are having another movie night (and will also hold our AGM). The AGM is being designed to be short and sweet as I am sure the majority of people will be keen to get into the movie watching part of the evening. We'll advise what movie will be shown closer to the date of the December meeting.

Christmas function

We're planning on running a family-friendly section Christmas outing on Saturday 5th December at Catchpool (Rimutaka Forest Park). For \$5 per person we'll put on some drinks and a BBQ dinner (catering for vegetarians / gluten free folk etc). We'll meet at 4pm and be eating around 6:30pm. You may want to go for a tramp in the park or a climb down the coast beforehand. Afterwards you have the option of camping overnight or heading for home depending on what you're in the mood for. Please register for the event (so we know how many we are catering for) by emailing us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz with names, numbers, dietary needs. We'll get a reminder out to you later in November.

Notification of Section AGM

The AGM of the Wellington section of the NZAC will be held at the Southern Cross starting at 6pm on Wednesday 2 December 2015. All NZAC members are invited to attend. There will be no boring speeches, painful reading out of reports or pontificating going on. Our intent is to ensure the AGM is as short as possible so we can get onto the fun part of the evening – watching a selection of climbing movies guaranteed to make you want to shut your eyes and stick your fingers in your ears and go lalalalalala. There is an embargo on their release until the 2nd so we can't tell you the titles until the night. Buy a committee member a beer and you

might be able to find out what they are. Reports will be circulated prior to the meeting to save time and avoid having to read them out at the meeting (phew!).

The agenda for the AGM is as follows :

- Introduction – Eric Duggan
- Voting for any contested committee positions
- Confirmation of committee for 2016
- Comments / feedback on reports

Current committee is as follows :

- Simon Williamson – Chair, Alpine course co-ordinator
- Eric Duggan – Co-Chair, Trip co-ordinator
- Mark Leslie – Treasurer
- Carolyn Ellis – Secretary
- Aviette Musin – Banffmeister and Avalanche training co-ordinator
- Mark Johnston – Committee member
- Nish Shah - Social Media Wizard (Twitter and Facebook)
- Josh Pemberton - Booking form developer
- Vincent Zintzen / Scott Taylor - Rock course co-ordinators
- Marketing and communications – vacant
- Librarian - vacant

All existing committee members have indicated they are happy to remain on the committee. Please forward any nominations for the 2016 committee positions to Carolyn at kaz1963@gmail.com by 27 November 2015. If you have any questions about what being on the committee entails please ask one of the existing committee members. We're keen that people understand that being on the committee isn't an arduous task.

View from the chair

Risk management! Who would have thought that it had anything to do with climbing mountains? According to an ex-policeman I spoke to recently, the most dangerous thing a climber can do is drive home – so you're safer in the mountains. I'm probably biased. Sunk cost bias, hindsight bias, and the mother of all biases, confirmation bias. The one I like the most is the 'I fell off the mountain and nearly got killed but I didn't so I'm a pretty good climber' bias. Then again most of us live in Wellington which has got to result in some kind of earthquake bias. When that one happens there will be a lot of forms to fill in let alone the mess to clean up. Perhaps we should sign a waiver? The insurance companies would love that. Rohan provided a great talk and some serious food for thought at our October section night.

In other news, section trips have all been fully subscribed (or cancelled). So Eric (the trips co-ordinator) has been flat out taking members climbing. The Arrowsmiths trip went exceptionally well (see trip report in the next edition). The upcoming back country ski trip happening this

weekend is also full with plenty of snow to give those skins a run. The follow up alpine course climbing trip, also happening this weekend, is also full.

The trad climbing course happening next month is full and now, due to unprecedented popular demand, we are running the NZAC summer climbing camp for the second year in a row at Tukino (see more details in this edition of Vertigo).

There have also been plenty of non-section organised trips by members (as evidenced by the demand for gear). Write up some of your trips for Vertigo and get a free week's gear rental. Our next movie night and AGM is coming up in December so come along and say yay or nay for the next committee and watch some seriously out there films.

We are also running a Pre-hospital Emergency Care (PHEC) refresher course on the 24th of November so if you would like to remain current contact the section and we'll arrange to get you on the course (Ts and Cs apply).

"The fact that I am still alive, when so many friends and others climbing the 8000ers have died is humbling. ... It is only death that has stopped many mountaineers from achieving the full tally of 14." Alan Hinks.

Section Nights are at the Southern Cross, 39 Abel Smith Street, Te Aro, Wellington on the first Wednesday of each month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings start at 6.00 pm with some nibbles provided – koha at the door. Grab a drink from the bar.

Upcoming Trips, Courses and Events

Wellington Section Trips

Please indicate your interest in leading or participating in trips by emailing the committee at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz and the committee will then proceed with firming up details around dates, etc.

November / December	Family Trip TASC lodge at Tukino bivvy near crater (Ruapehu)
December 2 nd	Section AGM and movie evening at Southern Cross
December 5 th	Christmas camping / BBQ at Catchpool
January 4 th – 10 th	Annual climbing camp at Tukino. There will be heaps of activities going on, including lots of family friendly stuff and alpine and rock climbing for a range of abilities. Register your interest or find out more by emailing camp@alpineclub.org.nz

Outdoor Training NZ Courses

OTNZ Wellington have a couple of courses coming up that may be of interest to NZAC members. If your navigation skills aren't crash hot or you've had some "moments" crossing rivers then these courses will get you on your way to being safer in the outdoors. There is a navigation course in November which will consist of 1 or 2 theory evenings (on a Monday night) and a practical outdoors session on 22 November. The cost of the course is \$75. The other course is River Safety which is taking place in Upper Hutt on Sunday 6 December. Theory in the morning, practical application in the afternoon. The final costs of this course are under discussion but will cost under \$100. If you are interested in either of these courses please contact otnzwgtn@gmail.com

Trip Reports

Alpine Lessons at Arthurs Pass

Words and Photos - Peter Laurenson

It was a happy situation. Winter, a blue bird weather window and my climbing buddy was back in the country. Seemed like the planets had aligned nicely for a climb at Arthurs Pass. Steve Henderson and I decided that Mount Rolleston, via Otira Valley and the slide, would fit the window nicely. We considered the taller Mount Murchison, but that required a much longer inward slog (who said "old farts?!").

We were feeling optimistic as we drove from Christchurch across to Arthurs Pass. The weather was beautiful and the forecast indicated four very settled days around Arthurs Pass – we couldn't believe our luck. But there had been heavy recent snowfall and the considerable risk of avalanches. So on arrival at Arthurs Pass we contacted one of the local alpine oracles to seek his advice. According to his extremely helpful website www.arthurspass.com, Graeme Kates is an ugly bugger who has lived at Arthurs Pass for the last 21 years.

Graeme confirmed our avo concerns and suggested that we give Rolleston a couple of days to firm up, also indicating that conditions might be a little better above Temple Basin. Good idea - a warm up on a traverse from Temple Col, over Mount Temple to Mount Phipps we thought. Next morning before dawn, Steve and I began our slog up to Temple Basin. It was chilly but a lovely clear morning. Just enough clouds to catch the warm colours of the rising sun and, as we ascended, an ever improving view of Rolleston across the valley. Graeme had suggested that we keep an eye on Rolleston to see what its upper slopes looked like as the day wore on.



Mount Rolleston, seen from below Temple Basin at dawn

To begin with, Rolleston was a huge lump of ice cream, glowing orange and then transforming into vanilla. A lot of snow, that hopefully the sun would melt; and then the coming clear cold night would freeze nicely. So we thought at least.

After checking in with the Ski Patrollers at Temple Basin we cramponed on up towards Temple Col. For the most part crampons weren't necessary in the deep snow, but we figured things might firm up higher. Across the valley Rolleston disappeared as clouds began gathering around the tops. Hmm, rather than melting, it appeared that a further dusting of snow was being dropped on top of what was already there. Somewhat at odds with the glowing weather forecast, but what we have to expect living on an island.



On Temple Col, looking north up the ridge to Mount Temple

From Temple Col it was evident that the eastern aspect was heavily snowed in. Our ridge route went directly north and up; and even that required waist deep plugging to start with. The ridge narrowed to a knife edge before broadening out again as we pitched and simul-climbed our way to the summit of Mount Temple, just half a km along and 140m above the Col. Even so, it took us a lot longer to reach the top of Temple (1,913m) than we had thought and, with heavy cloud closing in, we had to concede that Phipps would have to wait for another day. Lesson number one – how you interpret the map doesn't always translate to reality. Still, excellent practise and a fun day out.



On the ridge leading to Mount Temple's summit. Mount Rolleston is shrouded in cloud behind, right



Pitching up unstable snow just beneath the summit of Mount Temple

Next morning, before dawn under a crystal and starry sky, we made quick progress back along our track, until Steve started to struggle. Steve never struggles. He's one of those quiet, totally dependable types that just gets on with it. But this morning he was suffering from a nasty dose of heart burn. Perhaps back at the pub the evening before, the giant pizza we ate, along with maybe

an extra glass of vino than was smart, were taking their toll. Lesson number two – on a climb never discount the unlikely.



Sunrise on Mount Rolleston, viewed from the end of our previous day steps



Steve plugging up the Otira Valley after dawn, with a nasty dose of heart burn

I forged ahead to break trail while Steve beat off his gastro demons. At the end of our tracks of the day before I soon realised that the going under foot had not improved in the slightest, despite the lovely clear night. In fact, it just got worse as we headed up. By 10am we found ourselves sitting on a boulder near the head of Otira stream, in beautiful sunshine, under a cobalt sky. We were on an island surrounded by waist deep unconsolidated powder with zero base. Hidden holes into rock and tussock cracks everywhere.

How could this be? There had been no freeze at all, despite the cold clear night. Well, the snow was so dry that it wouldn't freeze. The melt we needed had not happened the day before and, here we were, still with a good eight hours of blue bird daylight, about to throw in the towel. Bugger and double bugger. Lesson number three - blue bird conditions are no guarantee of success on the hill.



When a climb becomes a swim – at our reluctant turn around point

After an early lunch we plunged back into the powder and began a snow plough, this time back along the stream bed, hoping it might be more interesting than retracing the higher route we had taken on the way in, so as to avoid deep snow in the stream bed. Oh yeah, deep snow in the stream bed. And of course, that's what we did encounter.

As we fought our way past a section of large boulders and water fall a small figure emerged further down valley, tracing our track. As we converged, a weather beaten face with a mop of sun bleached, wind blown hair came into focus. It had to be our Oracle, whom we had only spoken with by phone until then. Definitely rugged, but "ugly", as his website claimed, was a bit harsh I thought.



Plugging down the stream bed near the waterfall section

Graeme was aiming to reach 1,500m – about 200m higher than we had reached, so he could dig some pits to update his snow condition report. He assured us that conditions were bad, which made us feel a bit better about retreating in such fabulous weather.

Later, back in Wellington, I received an email from Graeme. He explained how he had not been able to reach 1,500m before avalanches started letting loose around him. On his retreat he then fell into a three metre hole, in hidden frozen avo debris, becoming mildly hypothermic as he struggled to extract a snowshoe-clad and tightly wedged foot. Lesson number four – if it's clearly iffy, best not to push it. The mountains aren't going anywhere.



Punch Bowl waterfall – a nice diversion when waiting for conditions to improve

Notices

Trek with the Himalayan Trust in 2016



The HIMALAYAN TRUST NEPAL REBUILD CHALLENGE 2016 is a 17-day trek through the stunning Everest region – from Lukla up to Ama Dablam base camp – in support of the Himalayan Trust’s Earthquake Rebuild Appeal. This is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to visit the schools and hospitals built by Sir Edmund Hillary and the Himalayan Trust and to help the Trust with the rebuild of a local high school – one year after the first devastating earthquake hit Nepal. Other highlights of the trip include a day exploring Namche Bazaar, a visit to Thyangboche monastery and breathtaking views of Mt Everest and the surrounding peaks. Throughout the trek you will experience the legendary warmth of the Sherpa people, which drew Sir Ed back to this region time after time.

Spaces are limited, so book now: <http://himalayantrust.org/trek/>

Naming of Mt Hopkins/Hopkins River

Anyone with information on the origins of the above names, please? Nothing found via online searching to-date, so any assistance appreciated, thanks. margaret@alpineclub.org.nz



Books to Giveaway

Via the Greymouth Rotary Bookarama I have the following books to give away for the price of P&P. Contact Murry Cave cavem@paradise.net.nz 029 200 2744

Hunt John - The Ascent of Everest 1953 (first edition)

Ullman James R - Americans on Everest 1964 (first edition)

Radcliffe Peter - Land of Mountains 1979

New Zealand Alpine Journal 1982

Great Walks of New Zealand by Craig Potton



From 1 October to 31 December 2015 Potton and Burton are offering NZAC members a 20% discount on this wonderful publication, out just in time for Christmas. A tribute to New Zealand's great walks, some of the finest walking traces in the whole world.

Log into the NZAC website here: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/membership/members-only> to obtain the discount code, or email margaret@alpineclub.org.nz , then purchase directly from the publisher's online store by logging in and applying the code at their checkout: <http://www.pottonandburton.co.nz/store/great-walks-of-new-zealand>

Notice of the 2015 NZAC AGM

The 2015 Annual general meeting of NZAC will be held in Christchurch at 7pm on Friday the 20th of November. Venue to be advised. Any Member may nominate a candidate for the positions of Honorary Secretary, Honorary Treasurer and the Executive, Accommodation and Publications Conveners. The role of Publications Convener is currently vacant.

In recent years, the AGM has been held alongside a debate. If you have any suggestions as to what the debate topic should be or who should participate, e-mail office@alpineclub.org.nz.

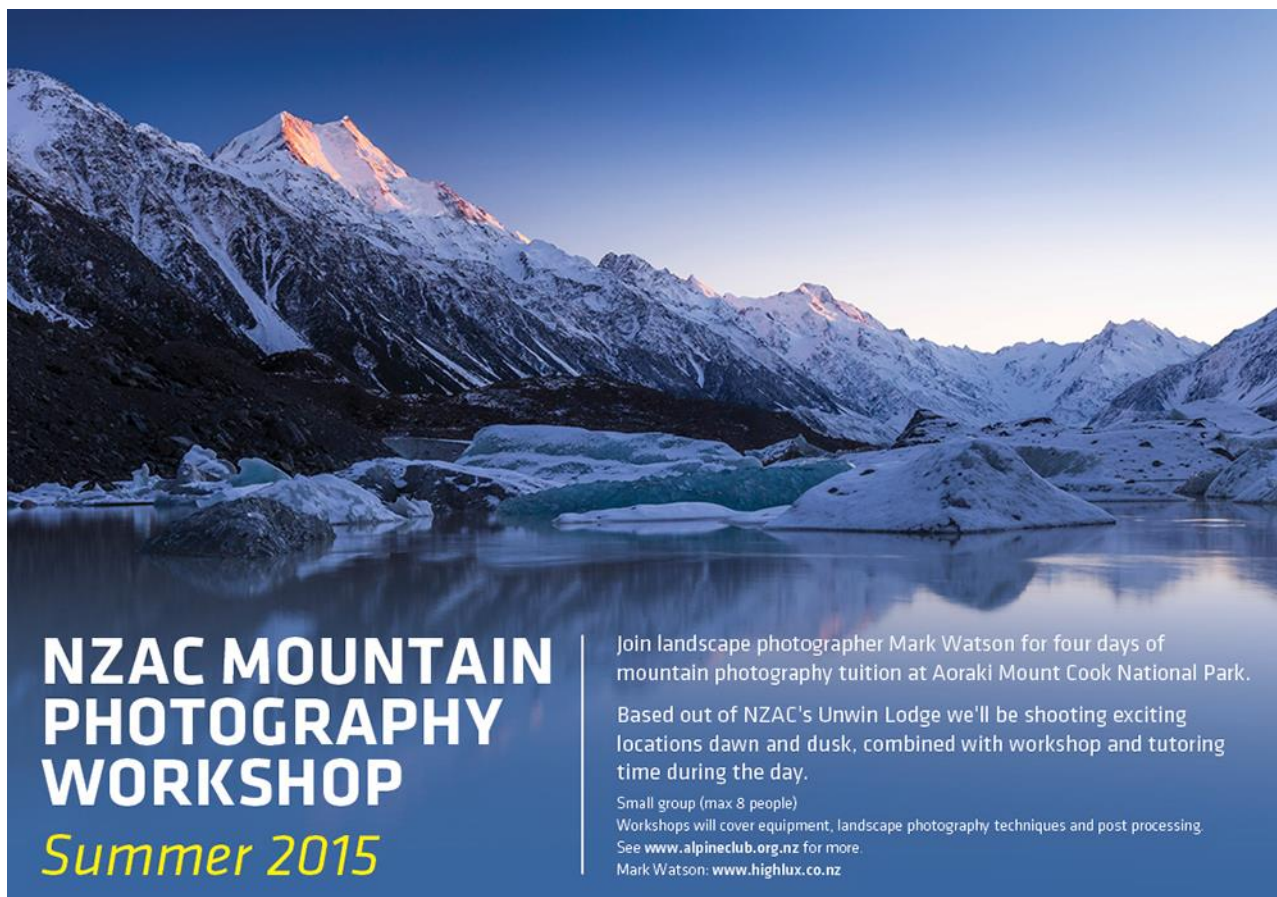
NZAC 2106 Alpine Calendar

Looking for the ultimate alternative to naff Christmas cards? Why not get your overseas friends and rellies one of the NZAC's 2016 calendars instead! Our calendars showcase the best from our very-own Photo Comp and so make a unique gift. We are taking pre-orders and expect these to be in stock around the second week of October.

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/product/nzac-alpine-calendar-2016>



Mountain Photography Workshop



**NZAC MOUNTAIN
PHOTOGRAPHY
WORKSHOP**
Summer 2015

Join landscape photographer Mark Watson for four days of mountain photography tuition at Aoraki Mount Cook National Park.

Based out of NZAC's Unwin Lodge we'll be shooting exciting locations dawn and dusk, combined with workshop and tutoring time during the day.

Small group (max 8 people)
Workshops will cover equipment, landscape photography techniques and post processing.
See www.alpineclub.org.nz for more.
Mark Watson: www.highlux.co.nz

For further details: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/event/2015/12/03/mountain-photography-workshop/mark-watson>

Wellington Section 2015 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Contact
Chairperson	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Co Chair	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Treasurer	Mark Leslie	027 338 4458
Secretary / Vertigo Editor	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Patron	John Nankervis	
Other Committee Members	Mark Johnston	027 924 4178
	Aviette Musin	021 0299 5390
Rock Drill Overseer	Kristen Foley	
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary		
Any media queries should be directed to:		
03 3777 595	National Executive Officer, Sam Newton	sam@alpineclub.org.nz



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